

[BACK TO BLOG](#)[RICH RESOURCE PAGE](#)

The Retirement Question Most People Never Get Asked

What life questions should I ask myself before retiring?

June 25, 2026 / 7 min read / David Talley



IN THIS ARTICLE

[Why This Question Matters](#)

[The Story Behind the Lesson](#)

[What the Usual Framing Misses](#)

[The Classroom Version](#)

[Questions to Ask Yourself](#)

[FAQ](#)

[Useful Terms](#)

Related Resources and Next Step

 [Reuse Notes](#)

Why This Question Matters

True retirement readiness is not just about knowing the numbers. It is about finding purpose, rhythm, and meaning in the next chapter when work is no longer the center of your days. For many, the switch from structure and purpose at work to “what comes next?” is the single biggest adjustment of retirement.

I see it often: people arrive asking how and when they can retire, or if they have enough. What they have rarely considered is what life will actually look and feel like the Monday after their last day at work.



The Story Behind the Lesson

I recently sat down with an executive in this exact spot. They had done well, grown their business, checked off all the big financial boxes, and were looking for guidance for the next phase. We could have spent all our time on tax, investments, and estate work, but instead, I asked: When September comes and you retire, what does your Monday actually look like?

What started as a practical question opened something deeper. We talked for ninety minutes, just working through what they hoped their days and life might look like after work. For them, it was the first real time they had named it out loud. You could feel the emotion. For a lot of people, that is the first honest conversation about their own future outside of work.

What the Usual Framing Misses

Most retirement planning is framed as:
Do I have enough? Will the numbers



will give me purpose and satisfaction after work is over? A list of things to do is not the same as a life you want to live.

Skipping this question can leave people with all the right numbers but a blank calendar, or feeling unsettled even if the projections say "yes." Mondays become the hard part.

The Classroom Version

If you are closing in on retirement or even just thinking about it, try this exercise: - Imagine it is your first Monday after career. What will you do? - Where will you find meaning and structure when there are no meetings, deadlines, or emails to answer? - If your calendar looks empty, does that thrill you or unsettle you?

This is not just about staying busy. It is about identifying what you want to learn, build, create, give, or enjoy in this phase. The answers are different for everyone.



Questions to Ask Yourself

- What are three things I want to look forward to when I no longer have work obligations?
- Are there relationships, hobbies, or causes I want to invest in, but haven't had space for?
- When I picture myself five years into retirement, what would make me proud or fulfilled?
- If I had to design a "perfect" week, what would that look like?
- Who will I spend my time with? Does my spouse or partner see this the same way?
- Am I avoiding this question because it feels uncomfortable or unknown?

FAQ

Q: Why does this question even matter if the numbers work? A:

Because money is only part of the picture. Many people find themselves restless, unhappy, or surprised by how open their days feel once work stops.



can make the transition more successful and rewarding.

Q: Is it normal not to know the answer

right away? A: Absolutely. Most people have not been asked the question, or have not thought past the financial side. Sometimes it helps to talk it out and see what surfaces.

Q: Can financial planning help with this, or is it personal? A: This is mainly a personal question, but your financial plan can help model possibilities and support what you want your days to look like. Sometimes it takes a few focused conversations for people to get clear.

Useful Terms

- **Retirement transition:** The shift from full-time work into retirement, including both financial and lifestyle changes.
- **Purpose risk:** The chance of losing a sense of meaning or direction in retirement, even if financially secure.
- **Calendar blankness:** The sense of emptiness or lack of structure many feel after leaving daily work routines.



Transcript

I just had a meeting with somebody who's about to retire, they're an executive, they make a couple million dollars a year and their life's work is this business that they have grown over the years and they were hiring me, assumptively, to figure out, you know, can I retire, how do taxes work, how should my investments be managed, I need my state funding done, all the things, but I ask them, hey, when you retire, I think it's like September, what are you going to actually do with your time, like it's Monday or Tuesday, like what are you going to do, like, well, I've got a lot of list of things to do and I presented that a little bit of like what, you know, like how much things do you really have and it hit them and we spent like 90 minutes just talking about their list of like what they want their life to be, they almost cried, it was just a, it was actually beautiful, I feel like a therapist even though I'm not, we didn't talk about anything other than like what they want their life to be and you could tell it was cathartic for them to just let that out, they'd never really thought through it, what happens most of the time is that



that's most of the time, or they are asked and they shrug it off and they don't really get to the heart of it or maybe even worse, they try but they can't because they don't have anything beyond their career and those are all real problems when it comes to retirement planning, when we're talking about retirement planning, we talk about the math and the investments and the taxes and like that stuff matters, yes, of course, we need to make sure that you're going to be sound and safe financially but what are you actually going to do, people need to think about that.

Related Resources and Next Step

- Explore other retirement transition questions on the Talley Wealth blog.
- Read about the Keystone Method for integrating life and financial planning.
- Ready to talk through your own transition? Schedule an Explore Call.



Compliance and Reuse Notes

Compliance notes: - This draft is for internal review only. - All statements are for general education. No individualized advice is implied. - Story is representative, not a testimonial or guarantee of future experience. - No investment, tax, or legal recommendation is made; language is hedged as required.

Reuse notes: - Core David language can be used in retirement transition page sections, client meeting prep, or self-reflection handouts. - Short answer and story segments could be excerpted for social posts, carousels, or persona pages. - FAQ and question prompts can support internal-linking for "What life questions should I ask myself before retiring?" - Can be adapted as a meeting starter tool or for use in Keystone Method transitions.

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RESOURCE PAGE

7 min read

Written by David Talley

Retirement Planning

Rich Resource

IN THIS ARTICLE

Why This Question Matters

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What the Usual Framing Misses

The Classroom Version

Questions to Ask Yourself

FAQ

Useful Terms

Transcript

Related Resources and Next Step

Compliance and Reuse Notes

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This is general educational information.
Investment, tax, and legal recommendations
should be based on your full situation.

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